

Pesticide Applicator Certification and Safety Training (PAC&ST) Program Performance Work Statement (PWS)

1.0 Scope

The Department of the Interior (DOI) requires contractor support to design, develop, and document an enterprise-wide Pesticide Applicator Certification and Safety Training (PAC&ST) Program. The program must comply with the U.S. Environmental Protection Agency (EPA) federal competency standards under 40 CFR Part 171, align with DOI Integrated Pest Management (IPM) policies, and support bureau-specific operational needs. The contractor shall develop the program framework, training curriculum, assessments, and documentation necessary for DOI to pursue EPA approval.

2.0 Background

Pesticide applicators must be certified and trained in the safe handling, application, and disposal of pesticides as required under federal law. At present, DOI does not operate a unified, Department-wide certification program. Among its bureaus, only the Bureau of Land Management (BLM) maintains an EPA approved program, and while that program is robust, it is designed specifically around BLM's operational environment. Other DOI bureaus depend on state run certification programs, which vary widely in structure, rigor, and delivery – from multiday, in-person courses to brief, self-paced online modules.

A standardized, Department-wide training and certification framework, supplemented by bureau-specific modules that reflect each bureau's operational needs, would create greater consistency in training quality across DOI. Such a framework would promote a uniform high level of applicator competency, strengthen protections for public health and safety, and ensure that all DOI applicators meet the same baseline standards regardless of bureau or duty station.

This initiative aims to establish a unified, adoptable certification and training program that satisfies regulatory requirements while incorporating best practices in adult learning, safety education, and operational relevance.

3.0 Objectives

The contractor shall:

- Develop a comprehensive, EPA compliant PAC&ST program tailored to DOI's mission and operational environments.
- Produce a complete program framework, including certification categories, competencies, training delivery methods, assessments, and recertification requirements.
- Create core and category specific training materials, exams, and instructor resources.
- Prepare documentation necessary for DOI to submit an EPA approval package.
- Ensure the program is scalable, accessible, and adaptable across all DOI bureaus.

4.0 Requirements and Tasks

Task 1 – Regulatory, Policy, and Training Analysis

The contractor shall review external regulatory and internal DOI policy requirements for pesticide use and identifying how they shape PAC&ST program obligations, flexibilities, existing content, and gaps.

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Federal regulatory and legal requirements, including:

- EPA's applicator competency standards (40 CFR 171)
- DOI obligations under EPA-administered statutes (CWA, CAA, RCRA, ESA, etc.)
- NEPA procedures and EPA coordination requirements
- Requirements for consistency with EPA-approved state certification plans
- Areas where DOI has flexibility in program structure and technical approaches

DOI policies, manuals, and training materials, including:

- Departmental IPM policies (517 DM 1)
- Bureau-specific pesticide and IPM manuals
- Existing DOI training on pesticide use, storage, handling, and safety
- DOI occupational safety and health requirements

The review shall address:

- Existing content suitable for integration into the PAC&ST program
- Gaps between regulatory requirements, DOI policies, and existing training

Deliverable 1: Regulatory, Policy, and Training Gap Analysis Report.

Task 2 – Benchmarking EPA Approved Certification Programs

The contractor shall evaluate:

- State certification programs approved under 40 CFR Part 171.
- Tribal certification programs approved by EPA.
- Federal agency training frameworks (e.g., USDA Forest Service, DOE, and DOD).

The review shall address:

- Core and category specific competency structures.
- Exam design, validation, and administration.
- Recordkeeping and quality assurance systems.
- Organization of EPA approval packages.
- State reciprocity options.

Deliverable 2: Benchmarking and Best Practices Report.

Task 3 – Mapping DOI Operational Needs to EPA Requirements

The contractor shall work with DOI bureaus to identify:

- EPA required program elements (core competencies, categories, exams, recertification).
- Bureau specific operational needs (e.g., wildland fire, aquatic applications, wildlife management).
- Gaps between current DOI capabilities and EPA requirements.
- Policy updates that will be required, including procedures for addressing pesticide misapplication.

This mapping shall serve as the blueprint for the PAC&ST program.

Deliverable 3: Needs-to-Requirements Mapping and Program Blueprint.

Task 4 – Development of the PAC&ST Program Framework

The contractor shall develop a complete program framework that includes:

- Applicator categories aligned with EPA categories.
- Required competencies for each category.
- Training delivery methods (online, classroom, field-based).
- Assessment methods (written exams, practical evaluations).
- Recertification intervals and continuing education requirements.
- Recordkeeping and data management systems.
- Oversight, quality assurance, and governance processes.

Deliverable 4: PAC&ST Program Framework Document.

Task 5 – Development of Training Materials and Assessments

In coordination with DOI IPM coordinators, bureau pesticide specialists, safety officers, and EPA regional contacts, the contractor shall develop (*All materials must be Section 508 compliant*):

- Core training modules (laws, safety, environmental protection).
- Category-specific modules—such as aquatic, forestry, and rights-of-way, to name a few.
- Instructor guides and participant manuals.
- Written examinations and practical skills checklists.
- Safety documentation and standard operating procedures.

Deliverables 5:

- Core and category specific training modules.
- Instructor and participant materials.
- Written exams and practical evaluation tools.
- Safety and SOP documentation.

Task 6 – EPA Approval Ready Documentation

The contractor shall prepare all materials necessary for DOI to submit an EPA approval package, including:

- Program description and justification.
- Competency matrices.
- Exam development documentation.
- Quality assurance and oversight plans.
- Recordkeeping and data management descriptions.

Deliverable 6: EPA Approval Ready Documentation Package.

5.0 Deliverables Summary

Deliverable	Title	Description
1	Regulatory, Policy, and Training Gap Analysis Report.	Identification of existing content suitable for PAC&ST integration and gaps relative to regulatory requirements, DOI policies, and current training.
2	Benchmarking Report	Evaluation of EPA approved programs and best practices
3	Program Blueprint	Mapping of DOI needs to EPA requirements

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4	Program Framework	Full structure of the PAC&ST program
5	Training Curriculum Package	Core and category modules, exams, guides, SOPs
6	EPA Approval Package	Documentation required for EPA review

6.0 Performance Standards

- All work shall comply with EPA regulations, DOI policies, and federal training standards.
- All materials shall be written in clear, plain language suitable for a federal workforce.
- All deliverables shall be Section 508 compliant.
- The contractor shall participate in recurring coordination meetings and provide iterative drafts for DOI review.
- All deliverables shall meet quality, accuracy, and completeness standards established at project kickoff.

7.0 Government Furnished Information (GFI) and Government Furnished Equipment (GFE)

DOI will provide:

- Relevant policies, manuals, and training materials.
- Access to DOI IPM bureau coordinators and subject matter experts.
- Guidance on EPA coordination expectations.
- Government Laptop
- DOI Personal Identity Verification Card.
- Network Access

Contractor Responsibilities:

- Accountability: Maintaining a record of all GFE.
- Maintenance: Ensuring the equipment is kept in good working condition.
- Return: Returning all equipment to the government once the training development is complete.

8.0 Period of Performance

The period of performance is anticipated to be 12–18 months from the date of award. Specific milestones and timelines will be finalized during project initiation.

9.0 Place of Performance

Work may be performed at the contractor's facilities. Virtual meetings, interviews, and document exchanges will be conducted as required. Occasional on-site visits to DOI bureaus may be required.

10.0 Security and Privacy Requirements

The contractor shall comply with all DOI security, privacy, and data protection requirements. No sensitive or proprietary data may be disclosed without authorization.